

are larger firms that go to market, often with a lot of foreign direct investment in them, and a reputation which needs to be protected. And so I see this change for sure in these CEOs.

Then there are, of course, smaller companies where you have a mix. There are some that still have a high risk appetite and are willing to face regulatory intervention. And there are some which may yet be small, but know that private equity (PE) will come for them, and they will come at a premium only if your track [record] is good.

Q: I want to get back to the start of your story, Zia. As a young woman, were you always going to be a lawyer, having been born into such an illustrious legal fold, or was there something intrinsically or philosophically attractive about law as a profession, which drew you in?

A: No, I don't think at the age of 20-25, I would have been attracted by the philosophy of law. As a young girl, it was very exciting to see my father practising as a lawyer. And he was in court every day, but the whole family would have dinner together. And then you would hear all these conversations—one side of the conversation anyway—through a walkie-talkie phone that existed in those days. It was always frenetic, energetic, argumentative, you know; having to win every time, fighting everything as a war, never a skirmish. And, given that I also have quite an argumentative nature, it appealed immediately.

For me it was almost like osmosis. I don't remember ever wanting to do anything but the law.

Q: It must have been heartbreaking to lose your father to Covid-19 last year. What are your key learnings from Soli Sorabjee, the jurist? Just inspiration as a young woman, or are many of the things in your guidebook drawn from what he taught you?

A: I think the value system, which he asked me to follow from the first day. I worked in America for nearly five years at a firm called Baker & McKenzie, New York, and came back essentially to get married and step into another world altogether. My desk was a small, 4 ft by 5 ft desk which I shared with my senior, and we had no secretary. It was sweaty and packed and full of papers. And, it was really starting from scratch. It was arguing in court as opposed to an M&A transaction that I would be working on in New York. My father was in Delhi, I was in Bombay. So, we never really got to practise in the same city. But he would always tell me—don't forget that the ultimate person you are arguing before is a judge, and that you are always an officer of the court; that your client is im-



portant, but never more important than your reputation with the judge. And he always used to tell me that if you say one thing wrong in one matter, before one judge, you have had it. They all have lunch together, and you would have ruined your reputation over one lunch. When you are brought up on this advice, you always have to do the right thing. That doesn't mean you can't fight heart and soul for your client. But there's a limit beyond which you need not travel. And, ought not to travel. Your sense of self-worth and confidence, and your ability to sleep at night without vexing about what you did during the day is far more important than winning that fight with the wrong means. So I've always grown up to acknowledge clients as important, but not vitally necessary to my existence if they cross my moral compass.

And with those values, the clients in turn respect you because they understand that the moral compass you deliver to them is for their benefit. I am not getting anything out of their good behaviour, I'm just protecting them. And slowly and surely as you grow older, and fatter and wiser, people take you a little more seriously. So that was one of my father's greatest lessons to me and counsel to me. Just make sure whatever you do, you're able to deliver the advice in a manner that you don't regret delivering the next day.